

# Open source, closed minds



Robert Sovereign-Smith, Editor

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**A**s you’ve probably figured out, we’re celebrating open source this month, and no, we’re not talking (just) about software. You’ve known us encourage the use of open source in the past, but this time we wanted to highlight all the other aspects of the open source philosophy. It’s not just about software, or Linux distros, but more about a way of life. Open source has extended to cars, gadgets, hardware, cooking, music, movies and much more. Although we’re covering all of the above in this issue, to help you understand how basically anything you can think of can be “open source” and community driven, including our own *Digit Open Source Project* (details on page 38), there’s still some confusion about how open, open source really is.

What started in 1985 as a paper titled the GNU Manifesto, by Richard Stallman, has grown exponentially, under the GNU license and the Free Software Foundation, into the biggest community initiative of all time. Now Stallman is (in)famous for being absolutely against all software with closed source, including freeware. His view has always been that unless the source is shared, software just isn’t truly free.

In very public arguments, Stallman has been criticised by other “evangelists” for being too rigid with his thoughts. To be honest, I’m inclined to agree with these criticisms. There’s no doubting the accomplishments of Stallman, and we probably wouldn’t have open source of any kind if it wasn’t for radical thinkers like him, but with the rate the world and its requirements are changing, can we continue to stick to ideals like an ancient religion’s diktats? This is why I hate the term “evangelist” – it’s basically a word used to describe someone who tries to convert you to their “religion”.

Over the years, I’ve avidly read views from both sides, as both have argued over the definition of common everyday words such as “free”, “freedom” and drawn distinctions between “free as in beer” and “free as in speech”. However, all this makes absolutely no difference to you and I, the everyday computer users. A lot of us use IrfanView, but it isn’t free for commercial use, or open source, so should you stop using it? Of course not – use what ever you feel like, and pay for things if you feel they will help you get your work done. That’s because, unlike the evangelists, we live in the real world, where we never get free beer, and rarely speak our minds –

either for fear of insulting someone’s sentiments, or getting beaten up.

Free software is good, and open source software even better, but some of the pontifications of the evangelists are just plain silly. Somewhere along the way, everyone’s forgotten that in 1985, the computing world was made up of mostly developers and other computing specialists, and it is just the opposite today. If we’re ever going to get the open source and collaborative philosophy to spread, and apply it to all the other facets of our lives that aren’t displayed on a monitor, we should first be allowed to think openly. Instead of bickering about whether a particular Creative Commons licence is truly open or not, or trying to classify an author based on the way he wants to share his works, why can’t we just applaud the desire to share? Isn’t some sharing better than none at all?

As open source moves away from software, the “rules” seem less realistic. It’s why the Creative Commons licences make more sense. Besides, as some people have put it, shouldn’t the proponents of “free as in speech” allow those who choose to keep their source closed to co-exist with open source? The Indian pharmaceutical industry seems to be the only ones to have it right – the laws were altered to distinguish between methods and end results. Basically, if X cures a certain disease, you can patent the way in which X is delivered to the body, or the way in which you manufacture X, but you cannot patent X itself. The government did this to make medicines more accessible to everyone, and save lives.

Personally, as a long time admirer of Stallman, I think he’s created something that’s outgrown everything else, including himself, and is now too big to control, much like the internet. Like the net, free and open source needs to be freed of shackles and allowed to ascend – with good, bad, and sometimes ugly results, if need be. Let’s remember that the basic principle behind open source, the FSF and GNU are pretty much all the same – let’s all work together and make life a lot easier for ourselves and everyone around us.

A handwritten signature in black ink, likely belonging to Robert Sovereign-Smith.

editor@thinkdigit.com